The Lord's Parables (6) - The Wheat and the Tares

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It is probable that there were few more effective ways of taking out one's spite on a neighbouring farmer in New Testament times than to sow amongst his newly-planted field of wheat the seeds of the weed, closely resembling wheat at all stages of its growth, called 'darnel'. Undetected as it often would be, its seeds were poisonous and, if harvested with the wheat, rendered the patience and the labour of a whole season absolutely useless. And if detected before harvest, attempts to pull it out invariably meant great damage to the wheat and the prospect of a loss few people could cope with.

Mean though it sounds, yet it was the kind of thing which people, having fallen out or seeking revenge for some offence or injury, occasionally resorted to. Everyone in New Testament times knew of it happening and most would have feared it being done to them. And, like so many other everyday occurrences and experiences, the Lord took hold of it in a parable to illustrate and to impress upon people a particular teaching He was trying to convey.

Jesus told them another parable: “The kingdom of heaven is like a man who sowed good seed in his field. But while everyone was sleeping, his enemy came and sowed tares (weeds) among the wheat, and went away. When the wheat sprouted and formed heads, then the weeds also appeared.

“The owner’s servants came to him and said, ‘Sir, didn’t you sow good seed in your field? Where then did the weeds come from?’ “‘An enemy did this,’ he replied. “The servants asked him, ‘Do you want us to go and pull them up?’ “‘No,’ he answered, ‘because while you are pulling the weeds, you may uproot the wheat with them. Let both grow together until the harvest. At that time I will tell the harvesters: First collect the weeds and tie them in bundles to be burned; then gather the wheat and bring it into my barn.’” Matt 13:24-30

It is the parable I have chosen to speak about in this sixth and last talk in this present series. In a very general, outline manner, the Lord explained to the disciples something of what it was He had been trying to teach by it. But there is so much more within, to which we now have access. And this is what I would like to look at with you.

As mentioned before, the tares which are referred to in the parable were a particular kind of weed closely resembling wheat. Indeed, only with great difficulty could it be distinguished from the real thing. Many would be deceived and taken in by it. And if people weren't watching what they were doing and on their guard against this kind of thing, the harvest would be ruined.

As is always the case where the kingdom of heaven is spoken of, what is meant is the Lord's kingdom in the hearts and minds of individuals everywhere. And what the Lord is doing here is warning us. He is warning us that though a good start may be made in establishing His kingdom in our lives, yet there are other agents at work attempting to undo and to destroy the good that has been done.

The parable presents us with a picture of a mind receptive of the Lord's truth and teaching and in which they have taken root. A good start has been made and there is every promise of an abundant harvest. But the situation is not without its complications. It never is. For the fact is that where the thoughts and affections of a person are concerned there are two sowers, one of whom is the Lord, forever trying to implant in us His precepts and ways and attitudes, and the other the enemy are evil spirits, who try to thwart what the Lord is doing with us and bring His efforts to nothing.

Regeneration, understood as the Lord’s kingdom being formed in our lives, always involves resistance, along with the difficulties and temptations that arise from it.

Even if it be only one truth that has put down roots into our lives the evil spirits will try to prevent it bearing fruit or coming to anything. And it is by no means an open opposition that is involved on their part. To the contrary, great cunning and subtlety is more often than not used: falsity and false ways of looking at things being dressed up so that they appear like truth and are not easily distinguished from it. It is just as it was with the wheat and the tares. Though a person may receive and accept the teaching of the Commandment concerning stealing, for example, yet having sat down to complete a Tax return the most convincing,

'legitimate', and as they seem, perfectly reasonable arguments can come to mind as to why he should not declare a certain item of income or over-state a claimable expense. Subtle? Yes, it is subtle. But, as we have noted, this is how evil spirits so often work. Not by open attack on our values and ideals. But by making a falsity seem like a truth and by deceiving us in the process.

Everyone has their moments when, spiritually, they are asleep; times when they are preoccupied by life in this world; times when they are overwhelmed by the 'appearance' of things; when faith and belief and one's convictions are in obscurity, somewhat in the background. And then it is, at these times - times of doubt and obscurity - that evil spirits are able to do their work, introducing ideas and reasonings which somehow get a foothold and are able to take root in our thinking and attitudes. And so convincing do they seem that we cannot tell the difference. As a consequence all of us, without exception, are a mixture. Tares growing with wheat. Falsities growing alongside truths. Evils in and amongst the good qualities that we possess.

Early on we cannot see that this is so. We think that all is good, that only wheat is growing. But it is as time goes on, we begin to sense and to become aware of the presence of something else. The tares become obvious. For all that we hadn't seen them before, now we do. It's like with the Commandment concerning false witness, for example. We receive it and resolve to live by it, ignorant at first of subtle reservations and false reasonings about it secreted in our minds. But in the process of time, and as the Commandment becomes more real for us; as its implications sink more deeply into our minds; as we come to see how important honesty is; so there are exposed those subtle reservations and false reasonings which have been there as well. And so it is with all of the Lord's truth and teaching which has been implanted in our minds and has put down roots with us. By way of another example, as the Lord's teaching about marriage grows in importance to us, so we become aware of the false and evil thoughts concerning it, they have been there all the time, of which we were unaware earlier. It was and it is, as the wheat grows that the tares become obvious.

It seems strange to us, knowing now what is meant by the tares, that the servants in the parable were forbidden to instantly root them out as they wanted to do. Premature action, as the householder pointed out, could easily damage and destroy the wheat. So they were to 'let both grow together until the harvest".

The reasons for this are obvious where our relationships with other people, particularly children and young people, are concerned. Although we may perceive mixed motives in others, including elements that are impure or self-centred, we are often too quick and injudicious in trying to correct them. A wiser course is to reinforce what is good—to affirm service and self-sacrifice, and to acknowledge genuine care for others—rather than to confront them primarily with criticism.

In rooting out the tares we can so easily damage the wheat at the same time.

And as for ourselves, it is unwise to become bogged down in self-reproach and discouragement when we notice questionable and selfish motives, or the presence of evil, in our approach to life. Once the nature of an evil—or the falsity in a particular mode of thought—truly becomes clear to us, we are able to gather it up and reject it from our lives. In the meantime we do well to get on with the job on hand; to attend to the wheat; to love and live the Lord's teaching. At the time of the harvest; when that teaching begins to bear fruit in our lives; the evils and falsities which we earlier detected - sensed and felt and realised were there - will be out in the open and exposed; and then, with no difficulty at all, we can get rid of them.

Regeneration, or the establishment of the Lord's kingdom in our lives, is never accomplished without opposition from evil spirits. Active as the Lord is, and as the heavens are, on behalf of our eternal happiness, so too are evil spirits, which breathe and instil their influences into us as well. And conscious as we will be from time to time of these influences yet we are not to be downcast by them. We are to press on confident as we can be that when the time is right, the Lord will give us the necessary strength to put those influences away from us.